

Cats and hyenas

Prehistoric cats were just as ferocious as their modern cousins and sometimes a lot bigger. Like modern cats, they had powerful, muscular bodies and sharp teeth for slashing flesh. Cats and hyenas share a common ancestor, and early species show features of both types of animal. The group includes some of the most efficient killers on the planet.

Smilodon

SMILE-oh-don



- **When** 5 million to 10,000 years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** N. America and S. America
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 6 ft (1.8 m)
- **Diet** Meat

Smilodon was one of more than 100 species of saber-toothed cat that scientists have discovered. It was a heavy, muscular animal and a predator to be reckoned with, able to wrestle victims to the ground before tearing open their throats. Despite their size, *Smilodon*'s teeth weren't strong enough to bite through the back of the neck, as a lion's can, and would break if they hit bone. *Smilodon* hunted a variety of prey, including bears, horses, and young mammoths. Fossils have been found together, suggesting it lived and hunted in packs as lions do.



◀ SABER TOOTH

Smilodon's canine teeth were more than 10 in (25 cm) long including the root. Like sabers (short swords), they were curved and had extremely sharp edges.

